of historical material. Instead, it "heavily depends on a constant arousal of passionate rage and hurt and has acquired the vocal support of large sections of our mass media which willingly fan the fires". Films like *Chaava* only help that cause, helping justify calls seeking retribution for historical slights, both real and perceived. All markers of the Muslim era, be it tombs or rituals, are drawn into an ever-widening battle—in courtrooms, on the streets, and from the pulpit of political rallies—over identity and legacy. What begin as legal disputes soon become bustling battlefields for broader ideological wars. In this high-stakes contest, history itself becomes the most contested territory of all.

The Sambhal Chapter

If *Chhava* re-enacted the battle by translating a 1979 novel by Shivaji Sawant onto celluloid, Sambhal wrote its own script. The legal and ideological battle over the Shahi Jama Masjid has reignited old fault lines in this western UP town. Hindu petitioners, led by Supreme Court advocate Vishnu Shankar Jain and seer Mahant Rishiraj Giri, claimed that Mughal emperor Babur ordered the destruction of the Harihar Mandir, a temple dedicated to Lord Kalki, to make way for the mosque. Their argument leans on historical texts such as the *Baburnama* and the *Ain-e-Akbari*, as well as an 1879 report by the ASI that they claim identifies Hindu architectural elements within the structure. The mosque's management committee counters these assertions, saying the site has been a place of uninterrupted Islamic worship since the 16th century. As such, Section 4(1) of the Places of Worship (Special Provisions) Act, 1991, prohibits converting or altering the character of any place of worship as it existed on August 15, 1947, except in the case of the Ram Janmabhoomi dispute. But the Hindu side has evoked the sub-section 3a, which exempts from this provision any place of worship that is an "ancient and historical monument or an archaeological site or remains covered by the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains Act, 1958...". Both Sambhal and Gyanvapi are protected sites under the ASI.

A court-ordered survey on November 19, 2024, conducted under the supervision of Advocate Commissioner Ramesh Singh amid heavy police presence, went off without major incident. However, a second such survey led to the eruption of violence; tensions had been building over the alleged lack of prior notice given to the mosque committee, fuelling suspicion about the intent of the exercise. When the surveyors returned five days later to complete their inspection, the atmosphere had grown volatile. Rumours circulated rapidly—that the administration planned to excavate under the mosque, that the *wuzukhana* (ablution tank) had been drained to make way for digging, and that the survey was a prelude to a larger push to reclaim the land as a temple site. By early morning, hundreds had gathered outside the mosque.

Stone-pelting soon followed. The police responded with tear gas and a lathi charge. There was also gunfire. By midday, four



ALAMY

AURANGZEB

The Emperor and His Resting Place

Aurangzeb, or Alamgir I, was the sixth and most controversial of Mughal emperors, whose name still stirs strong emotions more than 300 years after his death. He won the war of succession by edging out his three brothers. He deposed and imprisoned his father, Shah Jahan, and executed his elder brother, the liberal Dara Shukoh.

Aurangzeb is known for his religious bigotry and persecution of Hindus, Sikhs and Shias—unlike his great-

BY DECRYING MUSLIM MONUMENTS, ROADS AND PLACES NAMED AFTER THEIR RULERS, AS ALSO EVEN THEIR FESTIVALS AND RITUALS, HINDUTVA IDEOLOGUES HOPE TO SET RIGHT WHAT THEY THINK HAS HITHERTO BEEN A DISTORTED VIEW OF HISTORY